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Onions are my husband

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During the first few months, I learned the interactional skills and acquired the sponsorship of individuals that I needed to work at full speed. One of the middle-aged traders I often sat with noticed when the heat or crowds began to overwhelm me and found me quiet, dark corners and cool drinks. Learning the cycles of snacks and slack periods, I learned how to spend whole days in the market without overtiring myself or my various hosts. As my conversational ability expanded, the sheer novelty of seeing a white woman in the market also gradually wore off. I could now have extended conversations with a trader without subjecting her to the disruption of bystanders who blocked foot traffic by staring at me or who laughed and clapped when I began to speak Twi. Friends at the local university introduced me to an excellent new research assistant, Esi Munkoh, a recent middle school graduate whose linguistic skills and good judgment went far beyond reliability. She translated interviews as necessary, while continuing to teach me Twi and advise me on Asante etiquette and proper behavior.

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My new friends realized I was serious about moving out of my respectable minister's family house, which they considered highly appropriate for a young foreign visitor, when I started sharing with them the various real-estate scams and inflated rents I was being offered and felt forced to consider. Shocked, they found me very nearly what I was looking for within a few weeks, despite the tight housing situation. I rented a single room in a "passenger" or rental house within walking distance of the market, where several traders' families also rented rooms or suites and the landlord himself had interesting business ventures. The veranda and courtyard here were my first window onto the integration of trading operations and home life and enabled market traders to visit me comfortably. These neighbors became some of my closest

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associates, and our informal discussions included sensitive and difficult family issues.

One of the indications of my developing relationship with traders was my increasing social age. The raucous applause that greeted my halting Twi sentences at first mystified me. Asantes seemed otherwise rather blasé about Europeans, and Kumasi residents could effectively insult one who made too much fuss as *nkraaseni*—a villager. Then I noticed the same reaction in miniature to a toddler waving her diapered bottom in an attempt to dance. Like her, I cheerfully kept on trying,  20 and gradually proved myself teachable. Other unnerving responses also made sense later in comparison to interactions with children. One elderly women trader continually startled me by interjecting comments on the theme of “My husband! You will bring me cloth!” into my peaceful conversations with her middle-aged daughter at their stall. I had classified this as a rather bizarre case of the much-remarked honorary male status given women ethnographers, but very similar joking aimed at male toddlers and preschoolers was a popular pastime, proposing marriage and kin relations considered hilarious because of the boy's age and incomprehension. The same old woman gradually became one of my best sources of instruction, comment and companionship, and developed an especially close relationship with my research assistant, Esi. Toward the end of my stay, she even refused my pretext for a gift of money, but accepted with some indication of affection to share a pound of sugar I had managed to find, precious in its scarcity.

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